

CoARA Action plan:

Reforming Research Assessment Practices at CIIMAR



About CIIMAR

CIIMAR is a leading research and advanced training institution within the research ecosystem of the University of Porto, working at the frontier of Ocean Knowledge and Innovation.

CIIMAR was established in 2000 and mobilises a multidisciplinary, highly skilled and motivated team (580 members, including 240 with PhD). CIIMAR's mission is to promote transdisciplinary research, technological development, and training, contributing to advances in scientific knowledge and sustainability of the marine and coastal environments. CIIMAR fields of expertise cover three thematic lines: GLOBAL CHANGES AND ECOSYSTEM SERVICES; BIOLOGY, AQUACULTURE AND SEAFOOD QUALITY, and MARINE BIOTECHNOLOGY, addressing important economic and societal challenges and contributing to achieving UN Sustainable Development Goals. To deliver our mission and build a shared understanding and valorisation of the ocean, CIIMAR is strongly involved in partnerships, public engagement, and literacy. CIIMAR is classified as a Centre of Excellence in Marine Sciences by the Portuguese Foundation for Science and Technology, following an international evaluation process.

In 2024, CIIMAR signed the [Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment](#) and thus became part of [CoARA](#) (Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment), emphasizing the commitment of the institution towards fair assessment practices that maximise the quality and impact of research, towards responsible, inclusive, and qualitative assessment of research, researchers, and the institution. With this step, CIIMAR has committed resources to reforming research assessments, and has put forward an Action Plan, as detailed below.

CoARA working group at CIIMAR

CIIMAR has put together a group of its members in order to facilitate the implementation of CoARA Agreement Principles and Guidelines. The CoARA working group at CIIMAR is composed of seven researchers at different career stages, from different research lines, and one member of the Human Resources office.

The working group's actions involve collecting data regarding bias and peer review usage at CIIMAR (through surveys), enabling training activities, creating and reviewing assessment protocols for alignment with CoARA, piloting the implementation of these principles in the research assessments they perform, and overall supporting the wider implementation of the Action Plan.

Research assessment at CIIMAR: our commitment

CIIMAR evaluates research in several contexts: (i) for researcher positions linked to research grants, individual contracts, or other research roles; (ii) for scholarships it directly funds through its BYT program; (iii) for assessing its own researchers in career progression or the formation of new research groups. In addition, CIIMAR evaluates the overall performance of its research groups. Aligning ourselves with CoARA, its principles and guidelines, we will implement the commitments in the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment, namely:

- 1. to recognize the diversity of contributions to, and careers in research. This will be according to the needs and nature of the research.** *CIIMAR is a multidisciplinary research centre, so this implies that the different research areas within the centre will be addressed taking into account their specificities, when assessing research.*
- 2. To privilege qualitative evaluation through peer review, supported by quantitative indicators.** *In depth peer-review, rigorous and transparent, will be implemented and will take into account the specifics of the current Portuguese research and innovation landscape, while making sure that bias is minimized. CIIMAR will provide training to researchers on a regular basis for assessing quality and impact of different outputs through peer-review.*
- 3. To abandon inappropriate uses of traditionally used metrics such as the Journal Impact Factor and h-index.** *CIIMAR will provide training to its researchers to understand popular metrics so that the scope and limitations of each are clearly identified.*
- 4. To avoid rankings associated with research organizations to be used when assessing individual researchers.** *CIIMAR will implement training and guidelines to ensure that institutional prestige, perceived or through metrics, is not a factor in the individual research assessments that are carried out.*

5. **Review processes and guidelines.** *CIIMAR will develop guidelines to adapt current research assessment processes to align with CoARA principles.*
6. **Raise awareness and provide guidance.** *CIIMAR will promote sessions to raise awareness of the principles behind CoARA and will guide and train its researchers to become comfortable in assessing research using the CoARA-aligned guidelines. A CoARA portal on CIIMAR's intranet will be created with FAQs, templates, and progress.*
7. **Continuous evaluation of the reforms.** *CIIMAR will constantly monitor and evaluate the impact and changes brought about by the reforms implemented and make changes as necessary to continuously improve its research assessment processes. Progress will be shared internally, with CIIMAR's Scientific Council and stakeholders, and externally, with FCT, CoARA Portugal Chapter and other networks in which CIIMAR participates.*

Timeline of the Action plan at CIIMAR:

2024:

CoARA agreement signed and joined the coaline

Before December 31st 2025:

- CoARA working group formed
- First meeting of the action plan team
- Action plan developed
- Submit the action plan to the CoARA Zenodo Platform

Before June 30th, 2026:

- Define procedure to evaluate bias in research assessment at CIIMAR.

Before December 31^s, 2026:

- Survey and Report - Bias in research assessment at CIIMAR
 - Audit CIIMAR's current recruitment, promotion, and funding evaluation criteria
 - Identify reliance on metrics in internal and external assessments
 - Collect feedback from:
 - Group leaders and senior researchers
 - Early-career researchers (ECRs)
 - Identify alignment and misalignment with CoARA
- Guidelines for the assessment of researchers applying to research contracts or scholarships under the scope of research grants with CIIMAR as the Host Institution. Training of CIIMAR researchers and implementation.
- Guidelines for the assessment of researchers applying to institutional work contracts, not under the scope of a competitive research grant. Training of CIIMAR researchers and implementation.

Before June 30th, 2027:

- Proposal of guidelines for the assessment of researchers for career progression purposes to be submitted to CIIMAR's scientific council for ratification. Training and implementation.
- Guidelines for the assessment of research groups to be submitted to CIIMAR's scientific council for ratification. Training and implementation.

Before December 31st, 2027:

- Define procedure to evaluate the implementation process itself and the effects of the CoARA-aligned guidelines for research assessment at CIIMAR.

- Survey and Report – Implementation of the CoARA-aligned Guidelines for research assessment at CIIMAR.
- Discuss any additional measures or changes to implemented guidelines.

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